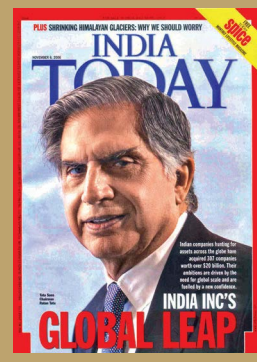
ON OVERSEAS ACQUISITIONS

India Today, Nov. 6, 2006

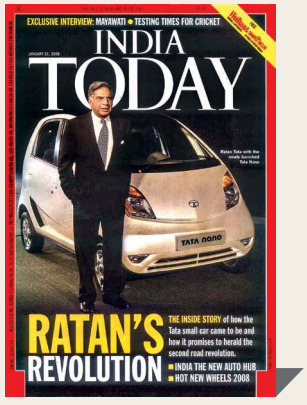
> We will continue to focus on enhancing the competitiveness of our Group companies in an increasingly globalised world



> We want to expand into geographies, where as a group we can have a meaningful presence

ON THE LAUNCH OF NANO

India Today, Jan. 21, 2008



> There is a section which thinks throwing something open to the masses is a disaster. But India is a country of people who have a great deal of unsatisfied demand. It is wrong to believe that people don't have the capacity to invest, own and improve the quality of lives

RATAN'S PERSONAL GEMS

- Used to draw caricatures of directors at board meetings when JRD was the chairman
- Was licensed to fly Jet aircraft and McDonnell Douglas helicopters
- Missed receiving a lifetime achievement award from (then) Prince Charles in 2018 because his pet dog was ill
- His off-duty attire was Armani vests, casual shirts and khakis. Holidays were usually private affairs, mostly in Europe



nies willing to spend big money and take huge risks. These included purchases of the UK's Tetley Tea in 2000 for $450 million, Daewoo Commercial Vehicles in 2004 for $102 million, Singapore's NatSteel the same year for $486 million, British steelmaker Corus in 2007 for $13 billion and the Jaguar-Land Rover from Ford Motor Company in 2008 for $2.3 billion. Some moves were more successful than the others, but what stood out consistently was the derring-do. By the time Tata stepped down in 2012, the group's turnover that was $4 billion when he took over in 1991 had grown by 25 times and crossed $100 billion. (It now stands at $165 billion.)

The protracted legal battle with his immediate successor Cyrus Mistry, who was sacked in 2016 following a boardroom coup, and the public battle with the Shapoorji Pallonji family, which owns 18 per cent in Tata Sons, probably was the sourest episode in his business life. Following the showdown, Tata came out of retirement to be interim chairman for a brief period before anointing Tata veteran and close confidant N. Chandrasekaran as group chairman. The Singur controversy where Tata Motors' Nano plant had to shift its factory from West Bengal to Gujarat in 2008 following farmers' resistance had been another tough episode. Tata then famously said, "If somebody puts a gun to my head, you either pull the trigger or you take your gun away because I will not move my head."

Despite his age, Ratan Tata remained in step with the 21st century avant-garde of business. Even a few weeks ago before his death, he was devoting a lot of his time to foster innovation at start-ups, most recently Goodfellows. In the past decade, Tata has mentored over 50 start-ups, including Lenskart, Zivame, Urban Company and Ola Electric. He continued to be chairman of Tata Trusts, the philanthropic arm of the Tatas, which holds 66 per cent stake in Tata Sons. Of late, in the winter of his life, he had also taken to sharing his past, via retro pics on Instagram. You see those same eyes, on a handsome face and rugged frame that would not have been out of place on stage in Parsi theatre—except that he never threw his voice. For, even as he strode the world of business as a titan, he dignified it with a quiet grace. ■